Treasure Island

A simplified retelling

Original story by Robert Louis Stevenson

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. The captain’s chest

My name is Jim Hawkins. When the old sailor arrived at my parents’ inn, I did not know how completely he would change my life.

He called himself the captain, drank heavily and watched the road for a man with one leg. Other sailors frightened him. After a visit from a blind man named Pew, he received a black spot: a warning from his former companions. Soon afterwards, he died.

My father had recently died too. My mother needed the money the captain owed us. We opened his chest to recover it, and I took a packet of papers before we escaped the men coming to search the inn.

I brought the packet to Dr Livesey and Squire Trelawney. Inside was a map showing an island and the location of buried treasure. It had belonged to the pirate Captain Flint.

The squire decided to fit out a ship. I was invited to go as cabin boy. The map promised adventure; it did not show who would betray us.

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2. The man with one leg

In Bristol, Trelawney hired a crew for the Hispaniola. Long John Silver, a friendly one-legged innkeeper, became our cook. He also helped recruit sailors.

I liked him. He spoke easily, used a crutch with remarkable skill and kept a parrot that cried out about pieces of eight. Captain Smollett, however, was uneasy about the voyage. Too many people already knew we were going after treasure.

At sea, I climbed into an apple barrel and overheard a conversation. Silver was not the honest companion he appeared to be. He and several sailors had served with Flint. They planned to take the treasure and kill or abandon the loyal men.

I remained hidden until it was safe to leave. Then I warned the doctor, the captain and the squire.

We were badly outnumbered. Silver did not yet know that we had discovered his plan. Our best hope was to remain calm and wait for a chance to act.

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3. The island

When we reached the island, some of the crew went ashore. I slipped into a boat without properly considering the danger.

On land, I saw Silver kill a sailor who refused to join the mutiny. His pleasant voice could change into something terrible with frightening speed. I ran into the trees.

There I met Ben Gunn, a ragged man who had been abandoned on the island years earlier. He had once sailed with Flint. He longed for ordinary food and a way home, and he offered to help our party.

Meanwhile, the loyal men left the ship and took shelter in an old stockade. Fighting followed. Some of our companions were killed, and the captain was wounded.

When I found them, I told them about Ben Gunn. We had gained a possible ally, but the pirates still had the ship, and their numbers remained dangerous.

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4. A small boat and a drifting ship

Silver approached the stockade under a flag of truce and demanded the treasure map. Captain Smollett refused. The pirates attacked, and we drove them back at a cost.

Later, I left the stockade again without permission. Ben Gunn had described a small boat he had made. I found it and paddled out towards the Hispaniola at night.

I cut the ship’s anchor rope so that the pirates could not use her so easily. The current carried us away. After a difficult night, I managed to board the ship.

Only one dangerous survivor remained aboard: Israel Hands. We made an uneasy agreement to move the vessel to a safer place. But he concealed a weapon and attacked me. I climbed into the rigging. When he struck, I fired, and he fell into the water.

I had recovered the ship, but I was shaken. Adventure had become something far more frightening than the stories I once enjoyed.

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5. In the pirates’ hands

I returned to the stockade after dark and discovered that the pirates occupied it. Silver caught me. I expected the loyal men to have died, but he said they had made an agreement and left.

Some of the pirates wanted to kill me. Silver protected me, partly because he hoped I might later speak in his favour. I had to trust the man whose cruelty I had seen in the woods.

He now possessed the treasure map. His crew accused him of poor leadership, but the map restored some of his authority.

Dr Livesey came to treat the sick pirates. I could not understand why he had given up the map and stockade. He spoke quietly to Silver and warned him to be careful when he found the treasure.

I promised Silver that I would not run away. Keeping that promise was difficult, but it gave us a fragile understanding when almost everything else depended on force.

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6. The empty pit

We followed the map into the island. A skeleton pointed the way. Then a voice imitating Flint called from the trees, terrifying the pirates. Silver steadied them and led them on.

At the marked place, we found an empty excavation. The treasure was gone.

The pirates turned on Silver. Before they could overwhelm us, shots came from the trees. Dr Livesey, Ben Gunn and another ally had arrived.

Ben had found the treasure long before our voyage and moved it to his cave. Once the doctor learned this, the map no longer mattered. Giving it to Silver had helped keep us alive while the loyal party secured what we needed.

We carried the treasure to the ship. Some surviving pirates were left on the island with supplies. Silver sailed away with us, but escaped at a port, taking a portion of the money.

I returned home with a share of the treasure. It brought

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comfort, but I had no wish to revisit the island. Sometimes, in dreams, I still heard Silver’s parrot calling across the sea.

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Words to keep

Mutiny — a crew’s rebellion against its lawful commander. Silver organised a mutiny.

Stockade — a defended place surrounded by strong wooden posts. The loyal men sheltered in the stockade.

Truce — an agreement to stop fighting temporarily. Silver approached under a flag of truce.

Ally — someone who helps your side. Ben Gunn became an ally.

Rigging — the ropes supporting a ship’s sails and masts. Jim climbed into the rigging.

Betray — to act against someone who trusts you. Silver planned to betray the ship’s owners.

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A question to carry with you

Why can a charming person be harder to judge than an openly threatening one? Which actions help Jim see Silver clearly?

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